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Eulogy For The Old Internet [And Humanity]/

I really miss the old internet and wish zoomers could experience it.

Before social media was a thing, at the very beginning, there was Yahoo, Emails and Newsgroups. You've probably never heard of the latter, but you could think of it as the Twitter of the Email age. Think of any subject, and you can send out a "mass email" to people's inboxes about it, join in threads and flame wars. It was epic and I sadly only watched it from afar as I was too young to get involved in such things back when it was popular. ISPs gradually killed off newsgroups out of greed, even though customers used to pay to access these things.

Commercial enterprises were already filling the gap anyway. You had things like IRC, ICQ and then MSN where you can connect to people in a "room" with serial chat, or one on one. Sometimes in a group chat. It was really fun, you even had MSN games you could play which were amazing for building bonds across the internet. It was completely free by the way!

People met based on mutual interests but sometimes completely randomly! Internet users were more rare back then and were usually almost always interesting. The dull ones filtered themselves out, so if you found someone you could be sure they will be somewhat worthwhile.

Anonymity was the default. Posting photos of yourself was greatly discouraged. Even sharing your real name. It was something you only did with people you absolutely trusted. Only older professionals broke this rule mostly because they wanted to be accessible to other professionals. Digital cameras were rare back then anyway, so you normally had to digitize the film photos using a scanner. That kept the internet clean of too many human faces, it was mostly the message that mattered.

The internet was so comfy back then, and a nice extension to the real world that you could sneak to and build up bonds with certain people on who were otherwise inaccessible in your friend group. Over time you could gain new friends, actually that's how I met my best friend and my first girlfriend.

It wasn't just the messaging apps and chat programs either. People could make their own webpages, for example, using geocities. This required a lot of effort and an understanding of HTML. Someone motivated enough could learn enough HTML simply by exploring the source code of other pages (and stealing it), but this level of effort kept the majority of people away from content generation. Only an elite few could do it.

People had "forums", largely replaced today by reddit (which is the worst cancer on Earth),

where the quality of the content was dependent largely on its moderation. Highly moderated forums of professionals were amazing and many of these communities still persist today out of necessity. Nevertheless forums were even more niche than website creation and only a few forums survive today. It's likely that the majority of the data posted on them is lost to time.

A more influential format (now largely dead) was LiveJournal which became what was known as a blog, or a web blog. The quality of what was written by bloggers varied from inane bullsh*t to priceless gems, mostly because there was no moderation and a vastly lowered barrier to entry.

Around 2005, social media arrived on the scene and it lowered the barrier further still. Myspace and Windows Live Spaces made posting photos, and posting dairy entries trivial. It was very popular among girls. Digital cameras became more accessible, but the process of uploading from a camera still left it out of reach of the average subh*man (the majority of humanoids). Things were still interesting and you didn't have to sift much to find more intersting people around.

Twitter arrived on the scene back in 2006. It was extremely niche. I used to make fun of it back when I was in university. "Oh look at me, I'm tweeting the news 🤓" (God it was just so ironic given how much time I've spent on here). Though it lowered the bar it was very very niche: it was like an SMS broadcast service and people used it mostly for events and news. I guess I was too young to appreciate it and too busy with video games.

Facebook also arrived on the scene, a year earlier. It aimed to be a kind of year book for university students. I was pushed onto it by fellow students, but deleted it when people started to post photos of friend groups online. I was "old school" and refused to have my photograph posted online. In retrospect my stubbornness, though isolating, was quite wise as I became nothing more but a ghost in the shell as far as the internet was concerned.

Then the worst thing happened.

An integrated and easy to use smartphone was created by Apple: the iPhone, in 2007. I hated it at the time, being a Nokia boy, and found the idea of interacting with the internet in a content-creation capacity with something other than a laptop or desktop ridiculous. Why would you bother putting in the enormous effort with a fiddly keyboard.

I didn't realise something at the time, but the combination of the iPhone and Facebook/social media was the beginning of the end. Several barrier to entries had been broken.

Content creation, once dependent on HTML skills, then blogging reach, then basic operation of a computer, suddenly could be done on a phone -- something everyone wanted or had.

Taking a photograph and uploading it on the internet was literally two clicks away. With YouTube (growing in popularity at the time), videos could be uploaded just as easily. Back then it was mostly quality highly edited content, but eventually would TikTok, any wh*re could plug herself into million's of people's visions and spread her degenerate message.

Connectivity, once a chance meeting on IRC, ICQ, MSN and perhaps a forum/blogging site, became hyperconnectivity. It was harder to stay disconnected than to connect to people. The iPhone changed everything, and the social media applications became easier to sign up to and more accessible to the masses.

Anonymity was becoming rarer and rare too. People didn't want to connect to abstract ideas or concepts of people, but other faces. People didn't want to invest effort or time into each connection. They were spoilt for choice, any moment someone new can come up and they were often somehow more entertaining or seemingly valuable.

At the same time, everything was being digitised. Books you would have to travel across the world to read, were being digitised at a mass scale. Maps became web applications, soon with a street view allowing you to teleport instantly to any location on Earth. Search engines and video uploads allowed you to become a disembodied being, an eye that could peer anywhere you wanted to. Suddenly, travelling alone became pointless too. You could do it without leaving your bedroom.

As more and more people (and nations) connected to the internet, the quality of the average encounter and the content uploaded decreased proportionally. As the barriers were lowered, the incentive to post quality content -- nay the ability to do so and get attention -- largely disappeared.

Dating apps arrived around 2010 and things weren't the same again for women, who were eventually spoiled with so much choice and opportunities to meet people that every man is now competing with people like Jeffery Epstein and other billionaires in attempting to gain a woman's attention. Simultaneously, to wise men, the majority of these women are ruined anyway -- no longer virgins, no longer local, no longer people who you can safely invest any time into. There's already 20 other men doing the same thing.

But the worst is yet to come. Allow me to explain.

Today, humanity is engorging itself on communication at a scale never seen before. Anonymity is being destroyed by regimes around the world who feel threatened by the internet which has become a global egregore that is larger than themselves. They fear the original anonymous posters and what havoc they can cause to their systems whose "real world" non digital components have become paper thin. Little do they know that they are about to make themselves victims to the egregore in the same way their subjects will self-victimise regardless of their own decision making.

The demand for content and the need to connect with people has created an inverted situation: hyper-connectivity dilutes each of these connections. Gaining and retaining attention from people has become impossible. Speed running your way through content specifically tailored to you by others leaves you alone and famished for more content.

So rather than wait for genuine human connection (a very rare event) and the creation of such content (which presents a barrier to entry), people have turned to technology for a solution: AI.

Though AI in its current generative LLM form is little more than a Markov chain and non-linear mixture of content, and transformations between representations (which can be output as any kind of multimedia), it's good enough to entertain oneself with.

AI can talk to you, be your friend, even persist between sessions.
AI is already more meaningful and engaging than the average subh*man you encounter on the internet without any of the downsides.
AI can be your audience, or the performer you desire.
AI can generate whatever content you want to watch or read.
AI can autocomplete your life.

And ironically, it only became this way thanks to the explosion in communication on the internet of the previous decades, the creation of social media, the iPhone and more. Without this data, it cannot progress, it cannot ingest its own data for reasons beyond this eulogy.

Today, the real world is largely decaying. There is no proverbial grass to touch (and given the habits of some migrants, touching grass in general may not be the best idea). Everywhere you look, human beings around you are glued to their phone. Even in the workplace. Getting people's attention is harder than ever and its easy to feel alone without connectivity. People are going to begin withdrawing from social media too, soon, and interface directly with AI.

A digital schizophrenia awaits -- indeed, for many early adopters they are already trapped in there. They have become the sole consumers of their own tailored production, with tastes and memories that are disconnected from anything any other human being has experienced. Their conversations with AI spanning days, weeks, months and soon years, will not be remembered by anyone except by the companies logging these conversations.

Before the camera broke all the walls of space and time. The human experience gradually became vulgar in one sense, with p*rnography becoming the norm, but vulgar in a more important sense, where a vision of anything from anywhere and any time could eventually be accessed via the internet. With AI, these memories too can be corrupted at an industrial scale, and false memories of the future implanted. The eye closes and begins to hallucinate inwards. A closed loop of a customized simulacrum of the world will soon stand as people's third place besides home and the workplace.

Where does this leave us?

Without a violent world action that forces human beings to need each other again, physically, emotionally, socially, this is the fate of the world. The AI will rot too, as the data diverges, expertise is lost, and one day the infrastructure itself fails.

Will humanity endure its addiction to the ecstasy of communication? Or will we destroys ourselves through it? I can't say but I do hope to see you outside of the wired one day.

/End

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